

American Gov./ Economics





About the Course

Students spend a term learning the structure of our local and state governments, then turn to key primary source documents related to our government before ending the year with an introduction to economics, focusing on the history of money, the banking system, and personal finance.

This topic is included in the following course(s): Citizenship: Grade 8 (U.S.)



Placement & Combining Tips

If a student hasn't studied the Constitution, consider having them take the 7th-grade government course first.



Scheduling

GRADE	SCHEDULE INFO.	BOOKS
8	American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 1 time/week 30 min	Dollars and Sense: A Kid's Guide to Using - Not Losing - Money Reading PDF

Sample Weekly View

Day 1	Day 2	Day 3	Day 4	Day 5
Citizenship: Grade 8 (U.S.)				
Ethics: Part 2 Community Read Alouds: Grades 1-12		American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 Current Events: Grades 5-8		Plutarch: Grades 6-8



Planning & Prep

Permission to print for non-commercial use. See Alveary group use policy to use lessons in a group context.

LINKS: Click text or scan the QR code in the top corner of the lesson plan pages to view online resources associated with the lessons.

Responsibility for previewing all links rests with the teacher. All links were checked at the time of publication; however, websites change frequently and may contain objectionable content. Please report broken links by contacting us through our website.

Citizenship: Grade 8 (U.S.)

☐ Make sure your student sets up a Citizenship Notebook. They will need a 3-ring binder, lined notebook paper, and 5 Tabbed Dividers. You can read more about how to set one up and suggestions for various sections in the document in Quick Links.

☐ As desired, plan for a read aloud time. Suggestions are provided in the Community Read Aloud Quick Link, but local favorites are highly recommended whenever possible.

☐ Make a Calendar of Events for Current Events lessons by drawing a calendar grid in a notebook (or print a blank calendar from the internet).



Books & Resources

For book rationales and purchase options, click the Book List link or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Book List Details](#)

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8



Dollars and Sense: A Kid's Guide to Using - Not Losing - Money



Reading PDF



Supplies

For supply list details and basic supplies helpful to have on hand, click the links or scan the QR code below.

∞ [View Basic Supplies](#)

(No Subject Supplies Assigned)



Quick Links

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

∞ [Extra Helpings](#)

∞ [Grade 8 Reading PDF: State & Local Gov](#)

Related Course Quick Links

∞ [Community Read Alouds](#)

∞ [Setting Up a Citizenship Notebook](#)

Click THIS text
or scan the QR
code for links.



American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

How To Teach



Prepare

Plutarch: Teachers will find it helpful to preread the entire Life first, and then preread the day's passage before each lesson. Mark any passages that should be omitted due to content. (In Anne White's Plutarch Project books, the recommended source for this course, objectionable content has already been omitted.)

Current Events: Preview the news source for suitability.

Most other citizenship topics don't require additional prep.



Recap

Connect back to the previous lesson. (Optional for Current Events).



Introduce

For news sources, show students how to scan the headlines to get an overview first and then choose a story to read.

For Plutarch or other books: Use a picture, a map, or an engaging question to prepare students to receive the story as relevant. You may talk about one or two unfamiliar words that will be crucial to understanding. It is not necessary to cover all unfamiliar words.



Read

Read the selection assigned or the news story chosen. For rich, dense, or more challenging books such as *Ourselves* and Plutarch, it is a good idea to read them aloud. Have students keep an eye out for things to add to their Citizenship Notebook, Book of Centuries, and/or Commonplace book.



Narrate

Have the students narrate orally or in writing.



Discuss

Give students an opportunity to share their thoughts on the story and any connections made. For current events, look up where events occurred on a map and ask questions to help students discern the quality of the piece. (e.g., Are there sources cited? Is there an obvious bias? If so, what do other authors have to say on this subject? Are arguments supported by evidence? Is that evidence credible?) Consider reading an alternative perspective.



Citizenship Notebook

Have students record important ideas in their Citizenship Notebooks.

American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8

[Click THIS text or scan the QR code for links.](#)



Term 1

WEEK 1 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 1

Introduction to State & Local Government

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

This term, we will learn about state and local governments. While we will focus on state and local government, we will sometimes reference the federal government to compare and contrast the state and local powers with federal powers.

→ READ

∞ Link: Reading PDF
p.2-4

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 2 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 2

Origins of Authority: Constitutions & Police Powers

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

States have two sources of authority that allow them to create and enforce laws: 1) constitutional powers and 2) police powers. These sources of authority are the basis for the laws and regulations that states pass, as well as the authority that states grant to smaller local governments, like cities and towns.

→ READ

∞ Link: Reading PDF
p.5-8

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.

WEEK 3 30m American Gov./ Economics: Grade 8 - Lesson 3

State Constitutions

Materials: Reading PDF

→ INTRO

Last week, we explored sources of power for states. One of these sources is the state constitution. This week, you will familiarize yourself with your state's constitution.

→ READ

∞ Link: Reading PDF
p.9

→ REFLECT

Narrate. Write a summary statement or draw a diagram describing the main ideas from this week's reading.